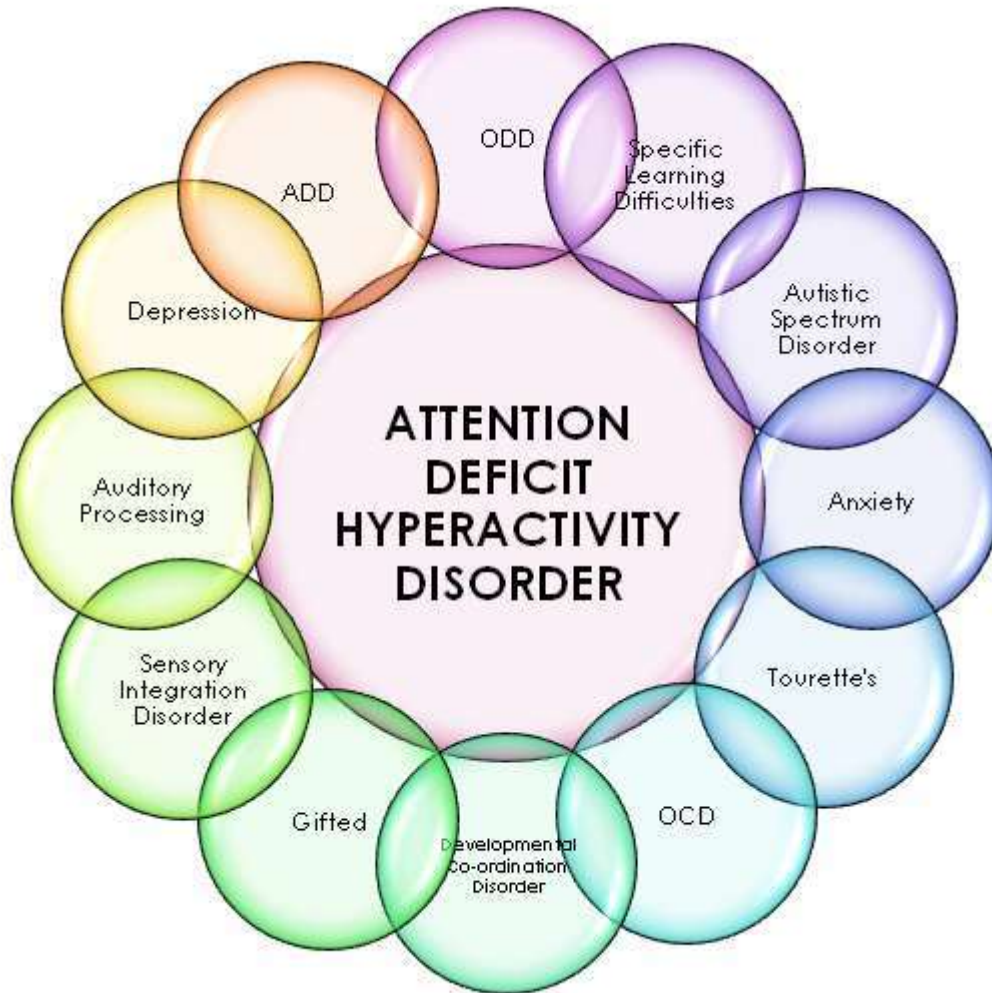


3.0 ATTENTION DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER (ADHD)



It is normal for children to have trouble focusing and behaving at one time or another. However, children with ADHD do not just grow out of these behaviors. The symptoms continue, can be severe, and can cause difficulty at school, at home, or with friends.

A child with ADHD might:

- Daydream a lot.
- Forget or lose things a lot.
- Squirm or fidget.
- Talk too much.

- Make careless mistakes or take unnecessary risks.
- Have a hard time resisting temptation.
- Have trouble taking turns.
- Have difficulty getting along with others.

3.1 Types of ADHD

There are three different ways ADHD presents itself, depending on which types of symptoms are strongest in the individual:

- **Predominantly Inattentive Presentation:** It is hard for the individual to organize or finish a task, to pay attention to details, or to follow instructions or conversations. The person is easily distracted or forgets details of daily routines.
- **Predominantly Hyperactive-Impulsive Presentation:** The person fidgets and talks a lot. It is hard to sit still for long (e.g., for a meal or while doing homework). Smaller children may run, jump or climb constantly. The individual feels restless and has trouble with impulsivity. Someone who is impulsive may interrupt others a lot, grab things from people, or speak at inappropriate times. It is hard for the person to wait their turn or listen to directions. A person with impulsiveness may have more accidents and injuries than others.
- **Combined Presentation:** Symptoms of the above two types are equally present in the person.

Because symptoms can change over time, the presentation may change over time as well.

3.2 Causes of ADHD

Scientists are studying cause(s) and risk factors in an effort to find better ways to manage and reduce the chances of a person having ADHD. The cause(s) and risk factors for ADHD are unknown, but current research shows that genetics plays an important role. Recent studies link genetic factors with ADHD.

In addition to genetics, scientists are studying other possible causes and risk factors including:

- Brain injury.
- Exposure to environmental risks (e.g., lead) during pregnancy or at a young age.
- Alcohol and tobacco use during pregnancy.
- Premature delivery.
- Low birth weight

Research does not support the popularly held views that ADHD is caused by eating too much sugar, watching too much television, parenting, or social and environmental factors such as poverty or family chaos. Of course, many things, including these, might make symptoms worse, especially in certain people. But the evidence is not strong enough to conclude that they are the main causes of ADHD.

3.3 Managing Children with ADHD

Raising a child with ADHD isn't like traditional childrearing. Normal rule-making and household routines can become almost impossible, depending on the type and severity of the child's symptoms, so you'll need to adopt different approaches. It can become frustrating to cope with some of the behaviors which result from your child's ADHD, but there are ways to make life easier.

Fostering the development of a child with ADHD means that you will have to modify your behavior and learn to manage the behavior of the child. Medication may be the first step in your child's treatment. Behavioral techniques for managing a child's ADHD symptoms must always be in place. By following these guidelines, you can limit destructive behavior and help the child overcome self-doubt.

Remember, every child with ADHD is unique, and what works for one child may not work for another. It's important to be patient, understanding, and willing to adapt your approach to meet the needs of the child you are managing. Seek out resources and support from professionals and other parents who have experience managing ADHD. Managing children with ADHD can be challenging, but with a few strategies in place, it can be made easier. Here are some general tips for managing children with ADHD:

- **Decide ahead of time which behaviors are acceptable and which are not:** The goal of behavioral modification is to help the child consider the consequences of an action and control the impulse to act on it. This requires empathy, patience, affection, energy, and strength on the part of the parent. Caregivers must first decide which behaviors they will and won't tolerate. It's crucial to stick to these guidelines. Punishing a behavior one day and allowing it the next is harmful to a child's improvement. Some behaviors should always be unacceptable, like physical outbursts, refusal to get up in the morning, or unwillingness to turn off the television when told to do so.
- **Define the rules, but allow some flexibility:** It's important to consistently reward good behaviors and discourage destructive ones, but you shouldn't be too strict with the child. Remember that children with ADHD may not adapt to change as well as others. You must learn to allow the child to make mistakes as they learn. Odd behaviors that aren't detrimental to the child or anyone else should be accepted as part of the child's individual personality. It's ultimately harmful to discourage a child's quirky behaviors just because you think they are unusual.
- **Manage aggression:** Aggressive outbursts from children with ADHD can be a common problem. "Time-out" is an effective way to calm both you and the overactive child. If the child acts out in public, they should be immediately removed in a calm and decisive manner. "Time-out" should be explained to the child as a period to cool off and think about the negative behavior they have exhibited. Try to ignore mildly disruptive behaviors as a way for your child to release his or her pent-up energy. However, destructive, abusive, or intentionally disruptive behavior which goes against the rules you establish should always be punished.
- **Create structure:** Make a routine for the child and stick to it every day. Establish rituals around meals, homework, playtime, and bedtime. Simple daily tasks, such as having the child lay out his or her clothes for the next day, can provide essential structure.
- **Break tasks into manageable pieces:** Try using a large wall calendar to help remind a child of their duties. Color coding chores and homework can keep your child from becoming overwhelmed with everyday tasks and school assignments. Even morning routines should be broken down into discrete tasks.

- **Simplify and organize the child's life:** Create a special, quiet space for the child to read, do homework, and take a break from the chaos of everyday life. Keep your home neat and organized so that the child knows where everything goes. This helps reduce unnecessary distractions.
- **Limit distractions:** Children with ADHD welcome easily accessible distractions. Television, video games, and the computer encourage impulsive behavior and should be regulated. By decreasing time with electronics and increasing time doing engaging activities outside the home, the child will have an outlet for built-up energy.
- **Encourage exercise:** Physical activity burns excess energy in healthy ways. It also helps a child focus their attention on specific movements. This may decrease impulsivity. Exercise may also help to improve concentration, decrease the risk for depression and anxiety, and stimulate the brain in healthy ways. Many professional athletes have ADHD. Experts believe that athletics can help a child with ADHD find a constructive way to focus their passion, attention, and energy.
- **Regulate sleep patterns:** Bedtime may be an especially difficult for children suffering from ADHD. Lack of sleep exacerbates inattention, hyperactivity, and recklessness. Helping your child get better sleep is important. To help them get better rest, eliminate stimulants like sugar and caffeine, and decrease television time. Establish a healthy, calming bedtime ritual.
- **Encourage out-loud thinking:** Children with ADHD can lack self-control. This causes them to speak and act before thinking. Ask the child to verbalize their thoughts and reasoning when the urge to act out arises. It's important to understand the child's thought process in order to help him or her curb impulsive behaviors.
- **Promote wait time:** Another way to control the impulse to speak before thinking is to teach the child how to pause a moment before talking or replying. Encourage more thoughtful responses by helping the child with homework assignments and asking interactive questions about a favorite television show or book.
- **Believe in the child:** The child likely doesn't realize the stress that their condition can cause. It's important to remain positive and encouraging. Praise the child's good behavior so they know when something was done right. Your child may struggle with ADHD now, but have confidence in the child and be positive about their future.

- **Find individualized counseling:** You can't do it all. The child needs your encouragement, but they also need professional help. Find a therapist to work the child and provide another outlet for them. Don't be afraid to seek assistance if you need it. Many caregivers are so focused on their children that they neglect their own mental needs. A therapist can help manage your stress and anxiety as well as the child's. Local support groups may also be a helpful outlet.

